Workshop Setup Guide: Git, VS Code & GitHub Copilot

Oct 25, 2026 · @Thuta

Finish Steps 1–5 **before the workshop**. They take about 20–30 minutes on home Wi-Fi, and you only do them once.

You need a laptop (Windows 10/11 or macOS) where you are allowed to install apps, and an email address you can open.

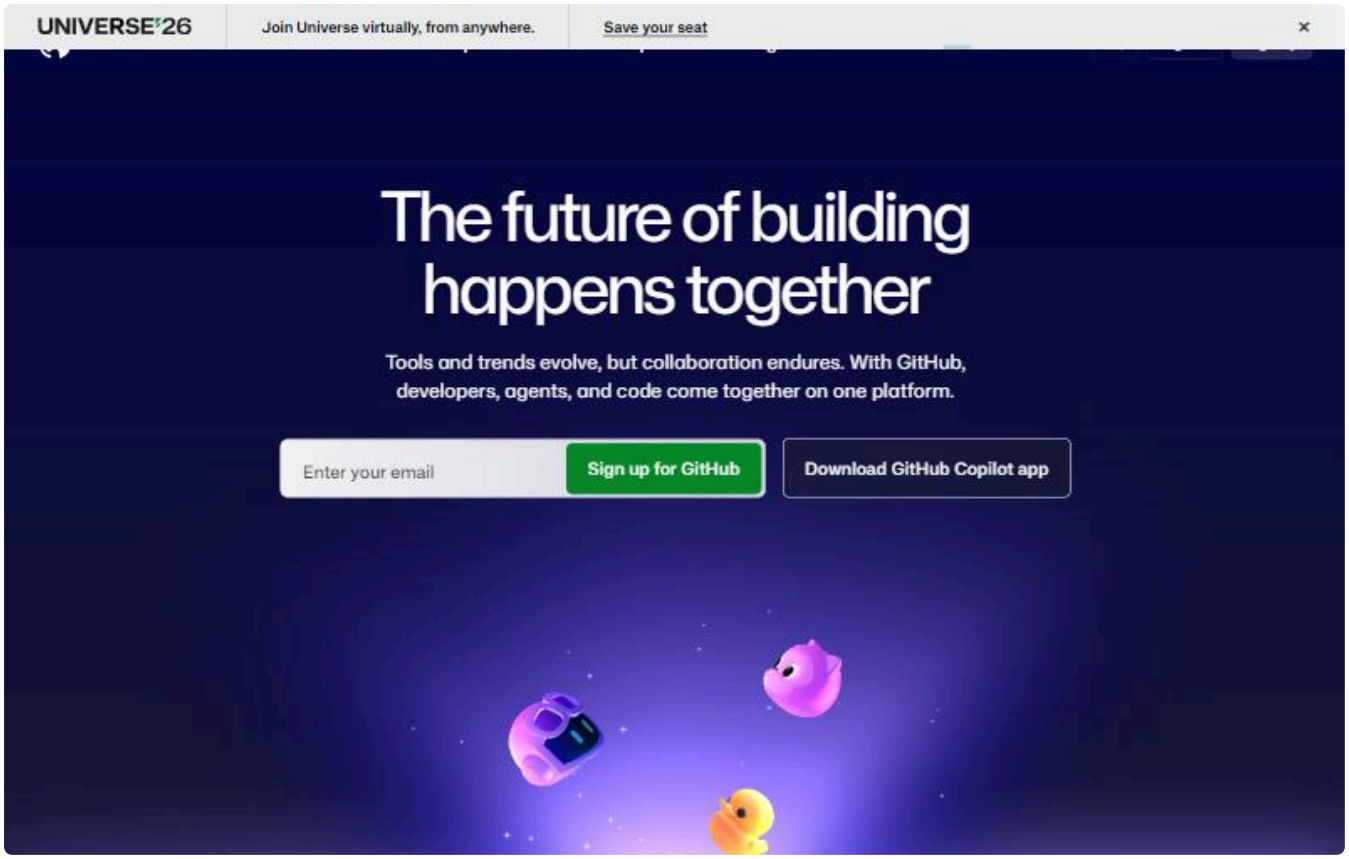
Step	What you get	Time
1. GitHub account	Where your code lives online	5 min
2. Git	Tool that saves and uploads your code	5 min
3. VS Code	The code editor we use	5 min
4. GitHub Copilot	The AI that writes code with you	5 min
5. Check everything	Proof that you are ready	5 min

Step 6 shows how to open your website once you have the project, which you'll do at the workshop. Stuck? Bring your laptop early and we will help, or check Troubleshooting at the end of this guide.

Step 1: Create a GitHub account

GitHub is where your portfolio's code is stored online. Already have an account? Skip to Step 2.

1. Go to **github.com**.
2. Type your email in the box and click the green **Sign up for GitHub** button.
3. Choose a password and a **username**. Your username appears in your project links, so keep it professional (for example `alex-tan`, not `xXgamer99Xx`).
4. Open the email from GitHub and type in the code to verify your account.



Tip: Use your school email if you have one. You will need it for free Copilot Pro in Step 4.

Write your username here: _____

Step 2: Install Git

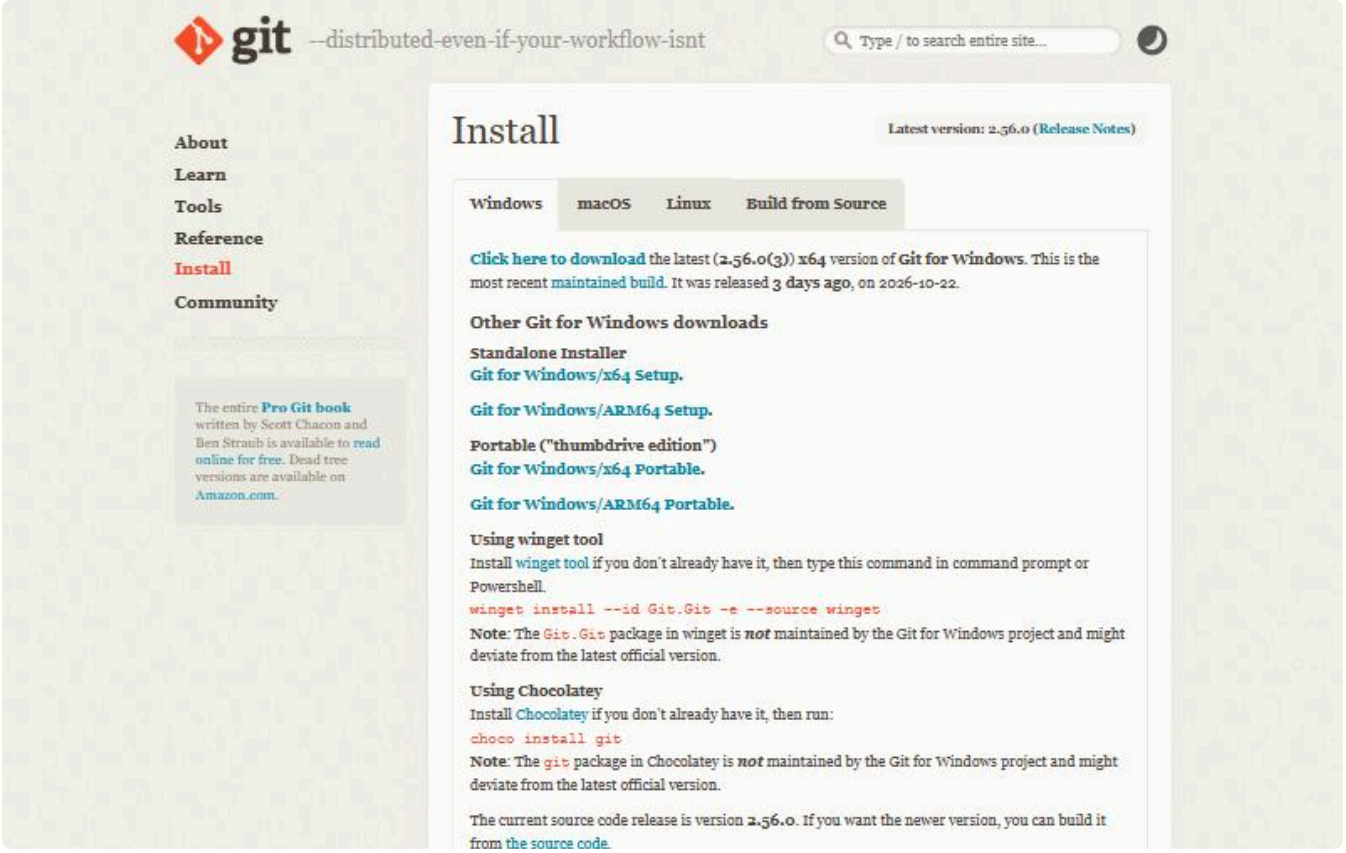
Git saves snapshots of your code and uploads them to GitHub. Follow the part for your laptop.

Windows

1. Go to **git-scm.com/install/windows**.
2. Click **Click here to download** at the top. The installer (`Git-…-64-bit.exe`) downloads.
3. Open the downloaded file and click **Yes** when Windows asks for permission.
4. Click **Next** on every screen, except these two:

Installer screen	Choose this
Choosing the default editor used by Git	**Use Visual Studio Code as Git's default editor**
Adjusting the name of the initial branch in new repositories	**Override the default branch name** and type `main`

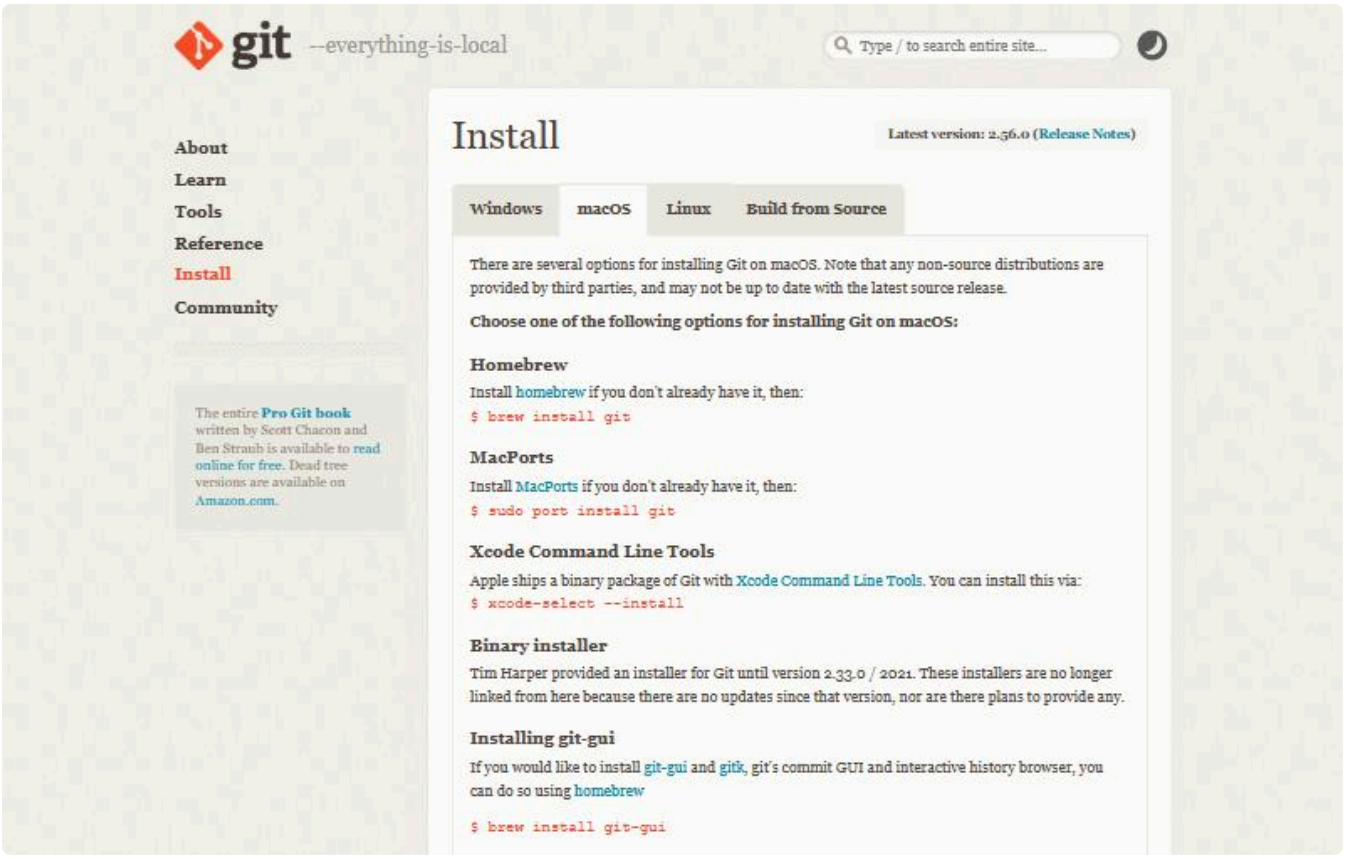
5. Click **Install**, then **Finish**.



Mac

1. Open **Terminal** (press Cmd + Space, type `Terminal`, press Enter).
2. Type `git --version` and press Enter.
3. If you see a version number like `git version 2.x`, Git is already installed. You are done.
4. If a pop-up asks to install the **command line developer tools**, click **Install** and wait until it finishes (5–10 minutes). This installs Git.

If no pop-up appears, type `xcode-select --install` and press Enter. More options are on **git-scm.com/install/mac**:



Tell Git who you are (Windows and Mac)

Open a new terminal (Windows: search for **Git Bash**; Mac: **Terminal**). Type these two lines, using **the same email as your GitHub account**:

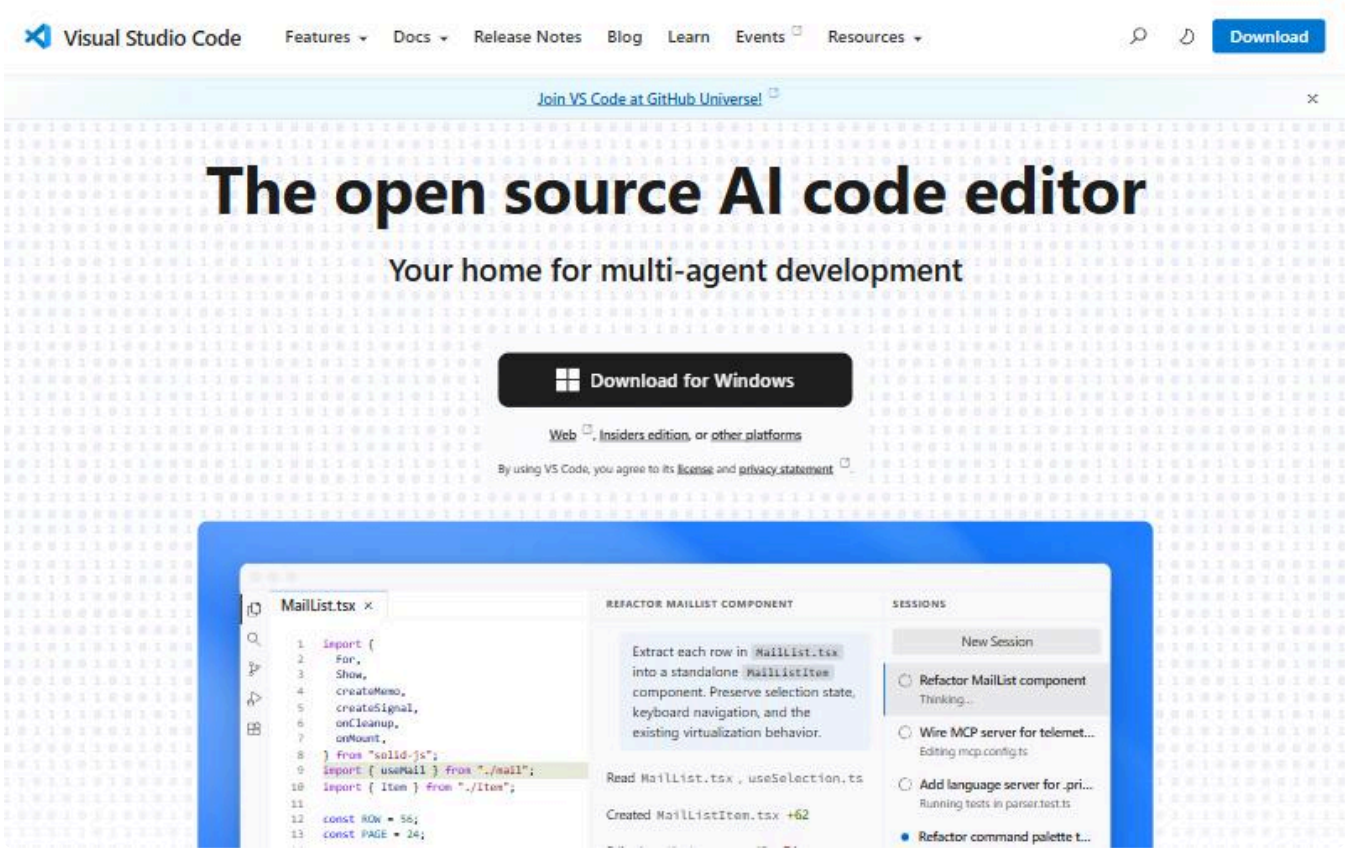
```
git config --global user.name "Your Name"
git config --global user.email "you@example.com"
```

Nothing appears after you press Enter. That means it worked.

Step 3: Install VS Code

VS Code is the free editor where you will write (and vibe code) your website.

1. Go to **code.visualstudio.com**.
2. Click the big **Download** button. It picks the right version for your laptop.



Windows: open the downloaded `VSCodeUserSetup….exe`, accept the agreement, and click **Next**. On the **Select Additional Tasks** screen, tick both **Add "Open with Code" action** boxes and keep **Add to PATH** ticked. Then click **Install**.

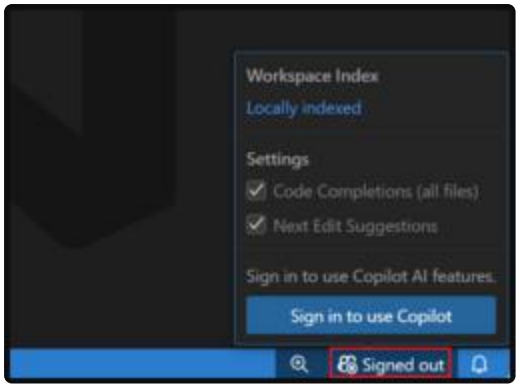
Mac: open the downloaded `.zip`, then drag **Visual Studio Code** into your **Applications** folder. Open it from Applications.

If VS Code opens and shows a Welcome page, this step is done.

Step 4: Turn on GitHub Copilot

Copilot is already built into VS Code. You only need to sign in with your GitHub account. There is nothing extra to install.

1. Open VS Code.
2. At the **bottom-right** of the window, hover over the **Copilot icon** in the blue status bar. It says **Signed out**.
3. Click **Sign in to use Copilot** (it may also say **Use AI Features**).
4. Choose **Continue with GitHub**. Your browser opens. Sign in with the account from Step 1 and click **Authorize**.
5. Back in VS Code, click **Open** if it asks to open a link.

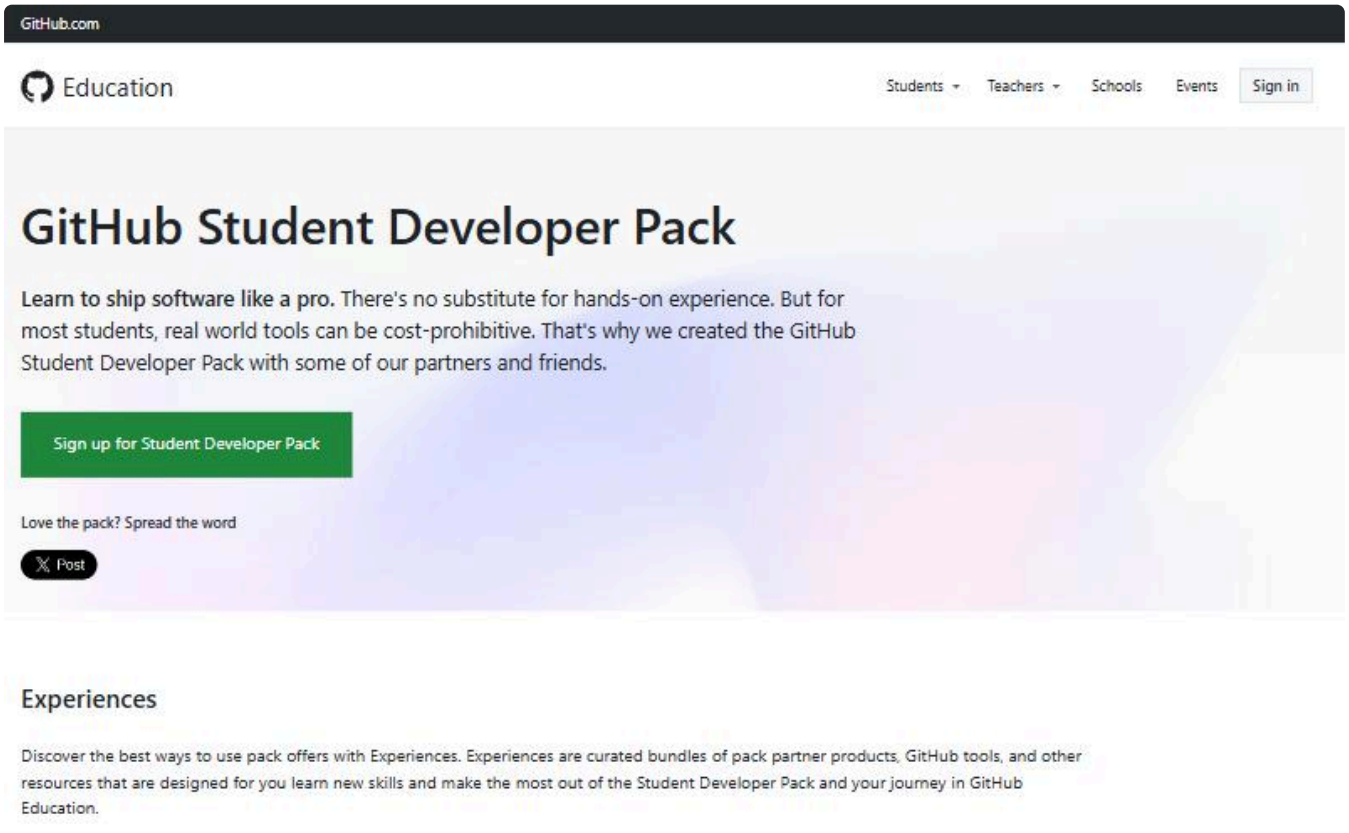


After you sign in, you get **Copilot Free** automatically. It has a monthly limit, which is usually enough for the workshop.

Optional: get Copilot Pro free as a student

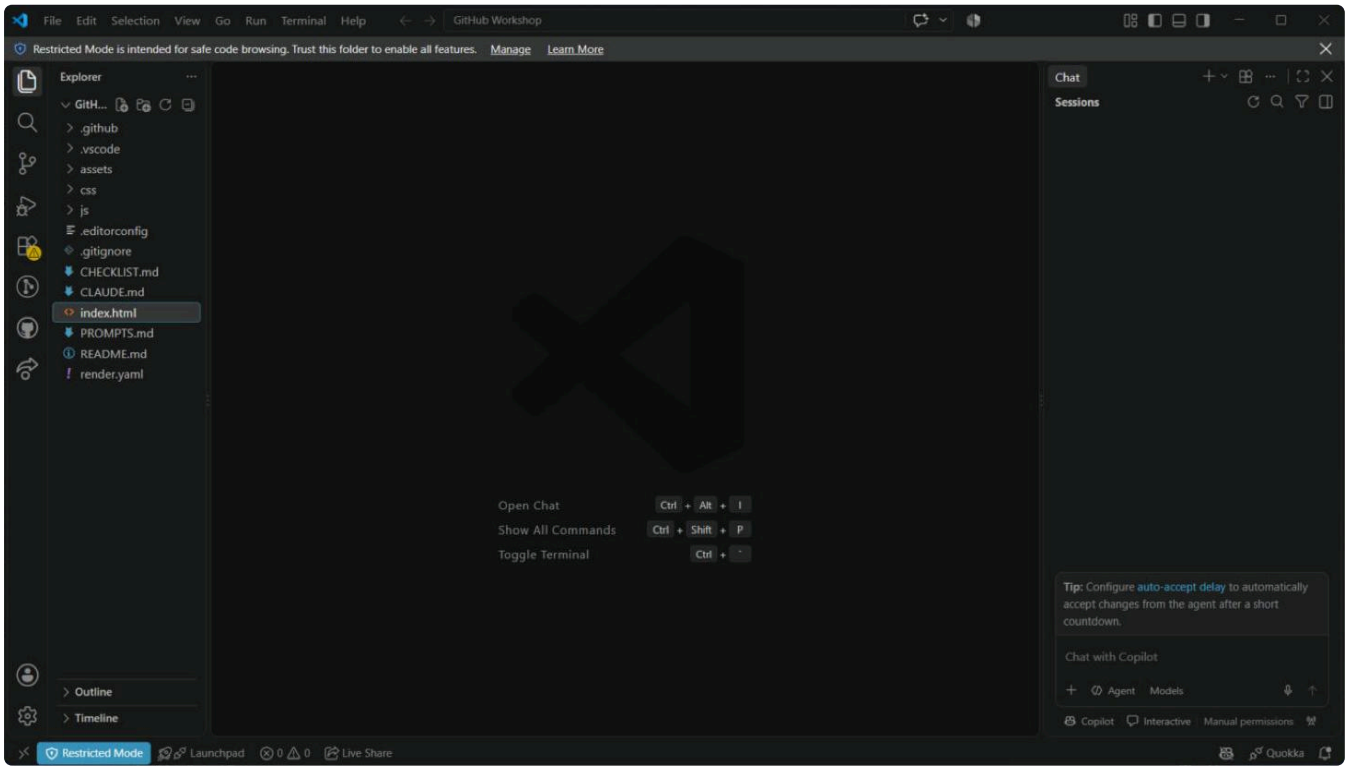
Students can get Copilot Pro (much higher limits) for free through the GitHub Student Developer Pack. Approval can take a few days, so apply early.

1. Go to **education.github.com/pack** and click **Sign up for Student Developer Pack**.
2. Choose **Student**, select your school, and verify with your school email or a photo of your student ID.
3. Once approved, Copilot Pro turns on in VS Code by itself. You may need to sign out and back in.

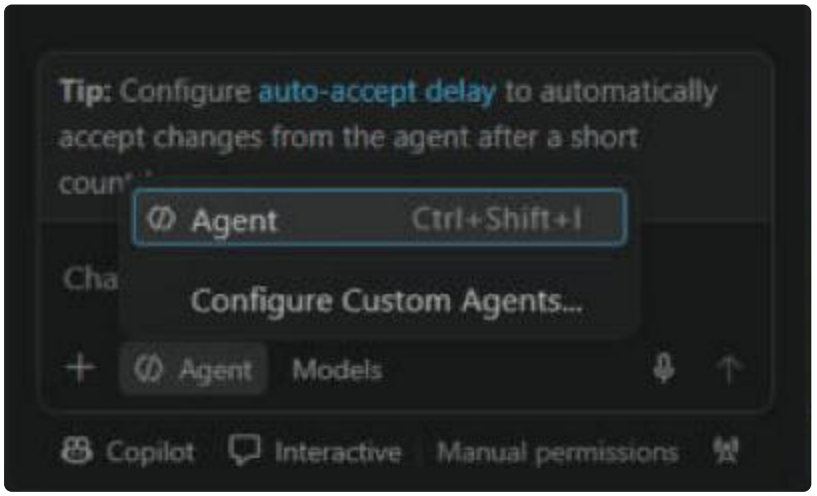


Find the Copilot chat

Open the chat with **Ctrl + Alt + I** (Mac: **Ctrl + Cmd + I**), or click the **chat icon** at the top of VS Code. The **Chat** panel opens on the right. You type your requests in the **Chat with Copilot** box at the bottom.



Under the message box, check that the mode says **Agent**. If it doesn't, click it and choose **Agent**. In Agent mode, Copilot edits your files for you.



Blue "Restricted Mode" bar at the top? When you open a project folder, VS Code asks if you trust it. For your own portfolio folder, click **Yes, I trust the authors** (or **Manage → Trust**). Otherwise Copilot cannot edit your files.

Step 5: Check everything works

If all four boxes below are ticked, you are ready for the workshop.

In VS Code, open the built-in terminal with **Terminal → New Terminal** (or **Ctrl + `**). Type each command and press Enter:

```
git --version
git config --global user.name
git config --global user.email
```

You should see something like this (your name, email and version number will differ):

```
git version 2.56.0.windows.1
Alex Tan
alex.tan@example.com
```

- [ ] `git --version` shows a version number
- [ ] `git config` shows **your** name and the **same email as your GitHub account**
- [ ] The Copilot icon at the bottom-right no longer says **Signed out**
- [ ] In the Copilot chat, you typed `Say hi in 5 words` and got a reply

Step 6: Open your website on your computer

A website doesn't need to be compiled or installed. It is just files: `index.html` is the page, and your **browser** reads it and draws it. "Running" your site means opening `index.html` in a browser. There are two ways.

	Option A: Live Server	Option B: start index.html
Setup	Install one VS Code extension	Nothing
Shows your changes	By itself, when you save	Only after you press F5
Use it for	Working on your site (recommended)	A quick look

Option A: Live Server (recommended)

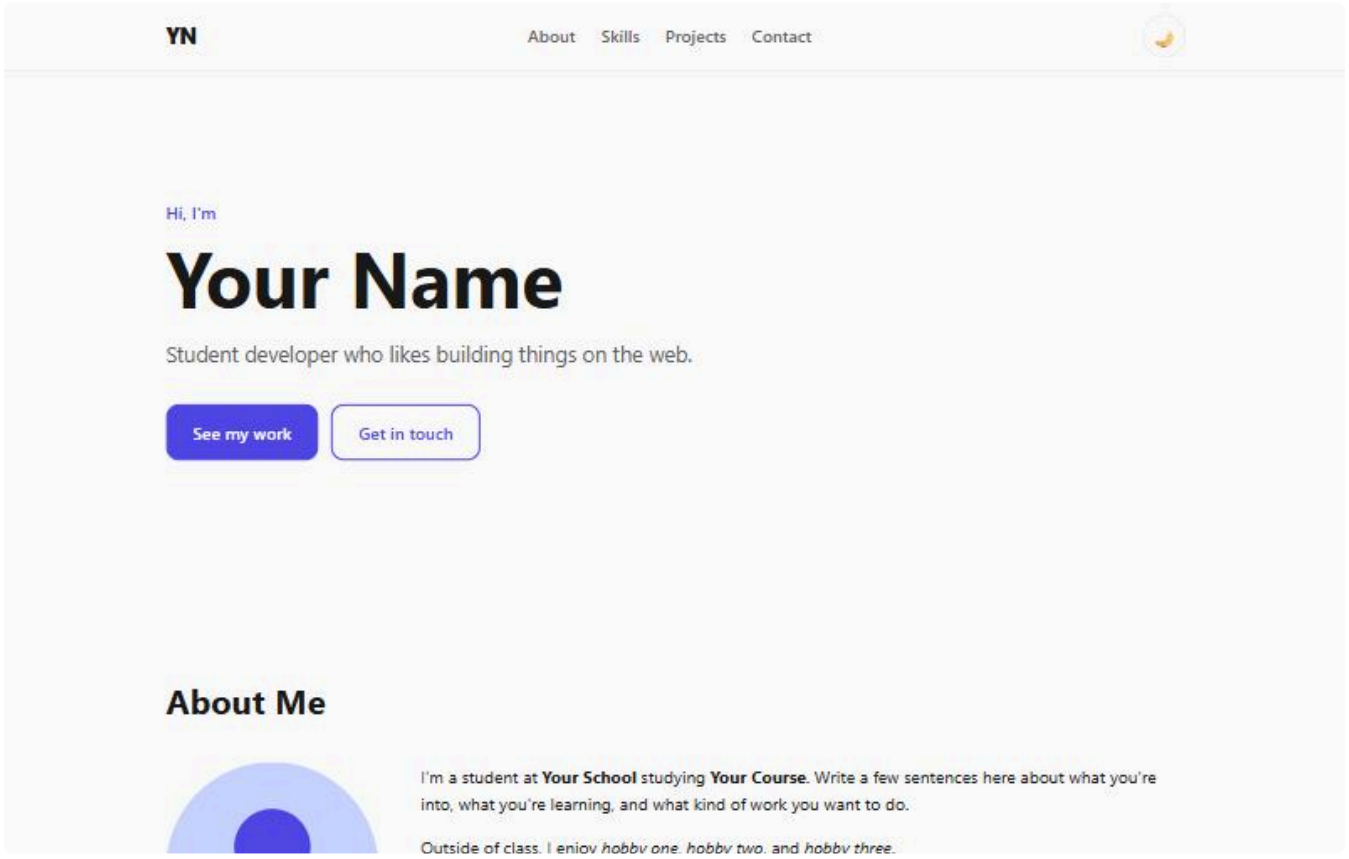
Live Server refreshes the browser every time you save, so you see Copilot's changes straight away.

1. **Install it once.** Click the **Extensions** icon on the left of VS Code (four squares). Search for **Live Server** (by Ritwick Dey) and click **Install**. If VS Code pops up "This workspace has extension recommendations", clicking **Install** there does the same thing.

2. **Start it.** In the Explorer on the left, **right-click** `index.html` and choose **Open with Live Server**. Or click **Go Live** in the blue bar at the bottom-right of VS Code:



3. **Your browser opens** at `http://127.0.0.1:5500/index.html`. This address means the site is running on your own computer, and only you can see it. It should look like this:



4. **Save to see changes.** Press **Ctrl + S** (Mac: **Cmd + S**) after each change. A white dot on a file's tab means it isn't saved yet. Tip: turn on **File → Auto Save**.
5. **To stop**, click the same button again. It shows **Port : 5500** while running.

Option B: start index.html

No extension needed. In VS Code, open **Terminal → New Terminal**. The terminal opens in your project folder. Type the command for your laptop and press Enter:

Laptop	Command
Windows (Command Prompt, PowerShell or Git Bash)	`start index.html`
Mac	`open index.html`

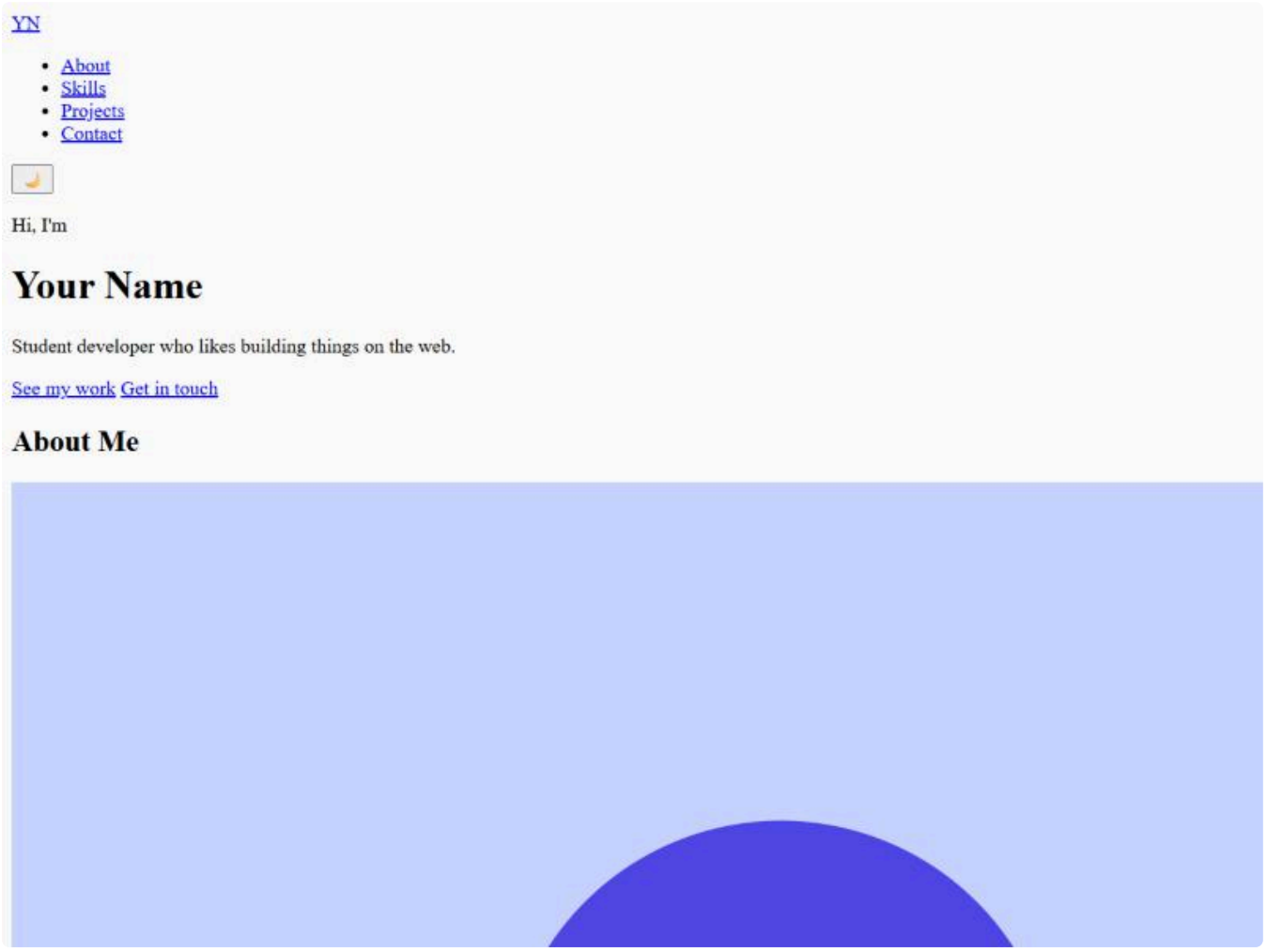
Your browser opens the page. The address starts with `file:///`. You can also just **double-click `index.html`** in File Explorer (Mac: Finder).

With Option B, the browser **does not refresh by itself**. After you save a change, click on the browser and press **F5** (Mac: **Cmd + R**).

Don't use npm

Commands like `npm start` or `npm run dev` are for other kinds of projects. In this project they only show `npm error Missing script`. Use Option A or B instead.

If your page looks like this, the styles didn't load



The browser couldn't find `css/style.css`. Make sure you opened the `index.html` inside your project folder, and that the `css` folder is still next to it with its original name.

Troubleshooting

Problem	Fix
`git` is not recognized / command not found	Close and reopen VS Code (or the terminal) after installing Git. Still failing on Windows? Reinstall Git and keep the default PATH option.
Mac: `xcode-select` says tools are already installed	Git is already there. Run `git --version` to confirm.
Windows asks "Do you want to allow this app to make changes?"	Click **Yes**. On a school-managed laptop you may need IT to install it for you.
No Copilot icon at the bottom-right	Update VS Code: **Help → Check for Updates** (Mac: **Code → Check for Updates**), then restart it.
Browser opened but VS Code still says Signed out	In the browser, click **Open Visual Studio Code** when asked. Or click the person icon at the bottom-left of VS Code and choose **Sign in with GitHub**.
Copilot says you reached your limit	You used up Copilot Free for this month. Apply for free Copilot Pro (Step 4), or use a friend's laptop at the workshop.
GitHub did not send the verification email	Check spam, wait 2 minutes, then click **Resend**.

Still stuck? Take a photo of the error message and bring it to the workshop. We will fix it together before we start.